believe that these first three generations of Muslims had a pure knowledge of Islam, whereas subsequently this was 'sullied and distorted by the introduction of innovations and the development of schisms in the Muslim community.'[70] Salafis around the world, and the Ahl-e-Hadith in South Asia, preach a return to the study of the original sources of Islam. The Ahl-e-Hadith recognize only the Quran and the Hadith as legal sources in Islam, and reject all of the schools of Islamic jurisprudence that interpret those texts. Following any school of jurisprudence is considered to be tantamount to worshipping that school's founder, which violates the Islamic tenet to worship only God. Instead, they advocate engaging in what is known as ijtihad [individual interpretation] of the Quran and Hadith, though that interpretation is supposed to be confined to those who are sufficiently qualified.[71]

The Ahl-e-Hadith sect is often derogatorily referred to as the South Asian version of Wahhabism.[72] Beginning during the colonial era, the Ahl-e-Hadith interacted with Wahhabis while on the pilgrimage to Mecca as well as through their associations with the members of the Arab ulema who migrated to India at the time. However, the Salafis in India began drawing a distinction with Wahhabis soon after forming the Ahl-e-Hadith movement. This was done primarily to avoid the British suspicion that they followed the jihadi tradition of Syed Ahmed Barelvi and the so-called 'Wahhabi movement,' which had rebelled against the Empire.[73] The Ahl-e-Hadith openly professed loyalty to the British Raj and formally requested to be differentiated from the Wahhabis, even as they retained connections to some of those involved in the struggle against British colonialism.[74] This provided the required room for maneuver to propagate the Ahl-e-Hadith concept of Islam in colonial India and the movement continued to call for an 'intellectual jihad against fellow Muslims on moral and ethical grounds.'[75]

In return, the Ahl-e-Hadith were 'hated by the masses' and condemned in Muslim law books.[76] Their aversion to any of the schools of Sunni jurisprudence or form of syncretism put them at odds with the majority of South Asian Muslims, who follow the Hanafi school of Sunni jurisprudence and incorporate local practices into their approach to Islam.[77] Ahl-e-Hadith adherents reveled in this opposition, and courted an 'exclusionary identity.'[78] For example, the Ahl-e-Hadith introduced a new and highly